



DELHI | Skirting the Edge

Poor infrastructure, bad planning, encroachment by slums and abysmal radar coverage. For years, India's aviation boom seemed akin to speeding along mountain roads: fast and narrow with little room to manoeuvre. Those words rang true with the tragic Air India Express crash at the Mangalore international airport which killed 158 passengers. The Boeing overshot the runway and rolled off into a valley. The airport, earlier meant only for light aircraft, saw a second 2.4-km-long international-length runway extended over a hilltop in 2006 for wide-bodied jets like the Boeing 747. This also meant that it had extremely constricted safety margins and now overshooting the runway has been established as the most likely cause of the crash. Like many Indian airports, Mangalore too did not have an approach radar that guides incoming aircraft through which the air traffic controllers could have warned the Air India aircraft. The crash has temporarily halted plans to extend the runway by another 1,000-ft; the precursor to recognition as a full-fledged international airport promised by Civil Aviation Minister Praful Patel at the spot just a week earlier. It has also raised questions about other under-construction hilltop airport projects like Sikkim's Pakyong Airport due for completion next year as well as the expansion and commissioning of airports in Belgaum, Bidar and Mysore. *by Sandeep Unnithan*

**DEBRIS OF THE
AIR INDIA PLANE
BEING REMOVED
FROM THE
CRASH SITE**

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is the
number of
airports in
Karnataka
—Bidar,
Belgaum
and Mysore
—that are
awaiting
inauguration.